

Pioneering new AI gadgets

In a move that feels both audacious and inevitable, OpenAI has announced it will acquire Jony Ive's AI device startup, io, in a \$6.5 billion all-equity transaction – ushering in what Sam Altman calls “the coolest piece of technology the world will have ever seen,” and what Ive describes in equal measure as “an extraordinary moment” in computing. When the poster boy of GenAI meets the most iconic industrial designer of the digital age, it's difficult to not get excited.

If I think about it, whether it was my very first clunky Pentium II PC in 1998, Apple's brushed-metal MacBooks of the mid-2000s, or everything that followed since Steve Jobs introduced the iPhone, the device that “redefined what a phone could be.” All of these hardware revolutions followed familiar paradigms of screens of glass with clickable mechanisms and a continued reliance on graphical user interfaces.

But over the last two years, Generative AI – ChatGPT, Gemini, Copilot, Midjourney, etc – has rewritten the script of software. Where software capabilities have exploded manifold in the last 2-3 years, hardware has languished poorly behind, unable to catch up and bound to interfaces designed long before neural networks could paint like Picasso or draft legal contracts in seconds.

This is precisely the point that Sam Altman made while unveiling OpenAI's io acquisition. By joining forces with Jony Ive, OpenAI isn't merely chasing fleeting gadget trends. It wants to stake a claim on the physical manifestation of AI in our lives going forward – the evolution from a cursor on a screen to devices that see, hear, interpret, and anticipate our intentions.

And what can one say about Jony Ive? The man who needs no introduction, at least to a gadgetophile. As the architect of devices that have become cultural relics in their own right – the iMac, the iPod, the iPhone – his touch defines modern gadgetry. Yet Ive himself has been searching for the next frontier, since leaving Apple in 2019.

“This is an extraordinary moment,” Ive says, “Computers are now seeing, thinking, and



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understanding. Despite this unprecedented capability, our experience remains shaped by traditional products and interfaces.” io was Ive's answer to solve this conundrum, a brand dedicated to “physical AI embodiments,” devices that would bridge the disembodied power of large language models with the immediacy of hands-on hardware.

The io acquisition hints at devices that might blur the boundary between software and hardware, perhaps through voice, gesture, or even neural interfaces. Imagine a pair of ear-worn assistants that overlay AI whispers on the world around you, or a bedside orb that dims the lights and reads you a bedtime story in your own voice.

Altman and Ive have already teased prototypes, though details remain under wraps. “Jony recently gave me one of the prototypes... I've been able to live with it, and I think it is the coolest piece of technology the world will have ever seen,” Altman gushed. That's high praise indeed, especially from someone who's built ChatGPT into a household name. But as with every major shift – think the move from command-line interfaces to GUIs, or from desktops to smartphones – the proof will be in everyday use.

Today, we're drowning in notifications, trapped in screens, and conditioned to tap, scroll, and swipe. The promise of “physical AI embodiments” is to liberate us from that treadmill – letting technology recede into the background so we can engage more fully with our surroundings.

But for that promise to be realized, hardware must feel intuitive, natural, and even delightful. It has to surprise us in small, meaningful ways. Like a gentle vibration to signal an emotion, a light pattern that soothes rather than distracts, a form factor that invites touch instead of demanding it.

Because at the end of the day, the devices that matter most aren't the ones with the flashiest specs but the ones that become part of our habits, habits that shape our days and, ultimately, our lives. Here's hoping Altman and Ive have not just designed technology – but have reimagined what it means to use it. **d**